

52.2 The Kingdom of Sicily

Charles came north against him and repeated his victory, driving back Conradin's supporters at the Battle of Tagliacozzo on August 23, 1268. "The better part of the enemy was destroyed with the edge of the sword," he wrote back to Clement IV afterwards, ". . . the slaughter of the enemey there was so great that what happened . . . on the fields of Benevento can hardly be compared to it." Conradin himself was captured as he fled from the battlefield. Charles imprisoned him for a year and then, in October 1269, had the teenager publicly beheaded for treason.[20]

The three-way dominion of the Holy Roman Emperors had disappeared, along with the line of Frederick II. Charles reigned in Sicily and southern Italy; the Lombard cities remained in revolt; and, four years after young Conradin's death, the German electors finally decided on one of their own, Rudolf, Count of Hapsburg, to be the next king of Germany.

Rudolf prudently remained in Germany, content with the title king of Germany and making no efforts to regain the empire. To be crowned Holy Roman Emperor, he would have had to go to Rome and appeal to the pope; and he preferred to stay home. "Rome is like the lion's den in the fable," he explained. "One may see the footsteps of many who have gone there, but of none who have come back."[21]